ALAGAPPA UNIVERSITY
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KARAIKUDI

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The inaugural function of a ñTwo-Day National Conference on Information for All: Changing Role of Public Libraries in Digital India Initiativesòorganized by the Department ofLibrary and Information Science, Alagappa UniversityKaraikudi, in association with Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation, Kolkata and Ministry of Culture, Government of India, New Delhi, was held on 2nd September 2016 at Alagappa University Convocation Seminar Hall.

Presiding over the function, Prof. S.Subbiah, Vice-Chancellor, Alagappa University, said that libraries have all along been remained as dynamic institutions and they have grown along with human civilization .The key to harnessing Indiaôs demographic dividend is education . He referred to the crucial role libraries play in fostering knowledge. He said that great leaders like C.N. Annadurai, Ambedkar, A.P.J.Abdul Kalam, etc., spent their golden time in libraries that shaped their great personalities. He said that public libraries not only act as information resource centres but also they act as informal educational centres. They are aptly called peopleôs universities and social institutions. The current Digital India Programme is a boon to every citizen and

it focuses on digital infrastructure as a utility to every citizen. He added that the ultimate aim of this umbrella initiative, as envisaged by the Prime Minister, is to provide Digital Empowerment to the citizens of this country. There are many advantages of Digital India as it will create employment; increase the literacy rate; improve the economy; pave way for transparency in government functioning thus checking corruption; and provide quick delivery of judgment in the judicial sector. At the same time he said the country needs a foolproof and dynamic system where such things can be established.

Dr. Arun Kumar Chakraborty, Director General, Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation, Kolkata and Additional Mission Director, NML, Ministry of Culture, Government of India, in his inaugural address, stated that Raja Rammohun Roy Library Foundation is supporting 34,000 public libraries in India. The motto of this foundation is ensuring the development of public libraries in India. Unlike private libraries, public libraries will be open to all at all times; and there will be no discrimination and no restriction. Public libraries are of the people, by the people and for the people. He added that the President of India has inaugurated the National Mission on Libraries which is entrusted with the task of building up 76 model libraries across the nation and the government has allocated 40 crores for this purpose. The Government has put forth four major schemes such as building model libraries, conducting capacity building programmes for librarians, making surveys on the functions of libraries

and the creation of national virtual libraries. Under this scheme 60000 library professionals will be trained. 6.5 lakhs of books will be digitalized under the National Virtual Library Scheme which would surpass the Googleôs services. He added acronym LAMP is becoming popular today that refers to libraries, archives, museums and preservation.

In his keynote address Dr. K.P. Vijayakumar, Former HoD, DLIS and Hon. Director, Center for Information Literacy Studies, University of Kerala, Thiruvananthapuram, said that the UNESCO has lauded the cardinal role of public libraries. In all the three revisions, the UNESCO hasemphasised the contributions of libraries in social empowerment. While speaking about the quintessence of public libraries in the digital era he exhorted the library professionals manning the public libraries to go in for ñde-skilling and re-skillingò in the current fastchanging technological world. The IT sector should be utilized for innovation and creativity which the Prime Minister often reinforces in his speeches. Referring to the changing face of libraries, he said the youngsters preferred digital materials in the place of print sources in the mobile phone era. 9000 journals are available in open access directory but unfortunately the research scholars and students are unaware of such provisions. He added that reaching the unreached through the digitalized library would be relevant in the present situation. The number of eôlearnerswill surpass learners in formal system of education at the global level. Some of the Career Guidance Cells attached to some public libraries have become popular among youngsters. Awareness should be created among the people by the librarians about the available resources in public library. He made mention of the M.S.Swaminathan Research Foundationôs innovative work of providing information to the fishermen community. He noted that the Indian Public Library Movement is gaining momentum and its objective is to create digitally literate people. He said the libraries can avail the required funds from corporates under the social responsibility scheme.

A Souvenir was released by Vice-Chancellor Prof.Subbiah and the first copy was received by Dr.Arun Kumar Chakraborty. Dr.A.Narayanamoorthy, Member of Syndicate and Dr.K.Manimekalai, Dean, Faculty of Arts offered felicitations. Earlier, Dr.S.Thanuskodi, Prof & Head, Dept. of Library and Information Science welcomed the gathering.Dr.R.Jeyshankar proposed a vote of thanks. Nearly 350 library professionals including librarians from Sivagangai, Ramanathapuram and Pudukottai Districts participated in the Conference.

Prof. V. Balachandran

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